enter into negotiations with Tibet except through the intermediary of the Chinese government'.[4] The Republican successors to the Qing did not give up their claim to Tibet, and for them suzerainty was no different from sovereignty.

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Just as the modern Chinese state claims the territories included in the non-Han empires of the Mongols and the Manchus, it extends the same principle to the territories which may have been occupied or even claimed by entities within those empires. When China occupied Tibet in 1950, it began to claim territories to which the Tibetan government had laid claim when the independent state of India took office in 1947.

Though the border between India and Tibet had been settled – in the Simla Convention of 1914 – along the highest watershed of the Himalayan mountain range, known as the McMahon Line, the Tibetan government asked for the return of large territories south of the Himalayas, which it claimed as part of Tibet. In a letter addressed to Prime Minister Nehru dated 16 October 1947, the Tibetan government laid claim to Sikkim, Bhutan, Darjeeling, Ladakh and others 'on this side of the river Ganges . . . up to the boundary of Yarkhim (probably in Assam)'.[5] While this was rejected by the Indian government, the Tibetan claim gave the Chinese a basis on which to claim the whole of the current state of Arunachal Pradesh. The monastery town of Tawang fell south of the McMahon Line but the monastery continued to be under the control of Tibetan ecclesiastical authorities. The Indian government forcibly expelled them in 1951, and this invited a strong protest from the Dalai Lama's administration, although Tibet was already under Chinese occupation. These unexpected and exaggerated territorial claims by the Tibetan government may have also dampened any Indian enthusiasm to support the cause of Tibetan independence from the Chinese.

Nevertheless, it should have been apparent to someone like Nehru, who possessed a keen historical perspective, to recognize the critical importance of Tibet to India's security interests. A quick look at the map would have shown that the headwaters of many of the major rivers of the Indian